is planning to start a programme that is expected to see 100,000 rabies vaccinations in a year.

With around 20,000 deaths annually, India accounts for 36 per cent of the world's rabies deaths, according to the World Health Organization. And dog bites cause almost all cases of rabies in the country. However, according to the Union ministry of health and family welfare, India has recorded a drop of over 60 per cent in the number of rabies deaths year on year from 2011 to 2018 (except 2017). Now, a mandatory shot is given to all stray dogs that are brought in for sterilisation.

COEXISTING WITH STRAYS

The data tabled by the Union minister for fisheries and animal husbandry in the Lok Sabha this year shows stray dog bites across India have reduced to 1.7 million in 2021 from 7.3 million in 2019. However, 1.45 million cases have already been reported from January 1 to July 22, 2022, indicating that the sharp drop in 2021 might have been due to Covid restrictions and fewer people out on the streets. But even at 1.45 million bites over six months, the figure this year may still be less than the 7.3 million cases in 2019. And sterilisation doesn't rule out all chances of a dog biting.

Experts say biting or attacking is a dog's defence mechanism and while a sterilised dog won't attack unprovoked, it will defend itself if faced with a threat. The Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960, defines acts that amount to cruelty to animals and makes them punishable. These include "beating, kicking, killing, mutilating or otherwise torturing any animal so as to cause them unnecessary pain or suffering". "Mischief by killing or maiming" an animal also violates Sections 428 and 429 of the Indian Penal Code.

One of the ways to reduce people's antagonism towards street dogs is to focus on what they do for us, say experts. Besides valuable companionship to many, dogs also help keep spaces safe at night. They are also our biological cleansers of trash, rats and other pests.

An example of coexistence is Sunil Kuttam and the 45-odd dogs he looks after in Delhi's Kalkaji Extension area. All the dogs are vaccinated and the respective RWAs have their certificates. Kuttam and his team help introduce new maids, drivers and couriers to the dogs to help build confidence and trust between both canine and human. If there is an aggressive dog, medicines to reduce anxiety and aggression are mixed into its food.

It is also important for people to know that the number of stray dog bites is not as much as believed and neither are strays becoming more aggressive. According to General Hospital, Ernakulam, Kerala, companion dogs, not strays, were the cause of 75.6 per cent of the bite cases in a six-month period in 2015. "Eating meat and being fed do not make a dog aggressive. It is an absolute myth. On the contrary, a well-fed dog is likely to be more trusting and less aggressive," says Satyanarayan.

The BMC is working towards countering misapprehensions through education programmes in municipal schools with plans to introduce them in private schools. "Touching a dog that you don't know, picking up puppies with a mother around, throwing a stone, touching the animal while it is eating and pulling its tail should be avoided. If a dog is chasing, don't run. You need to make children aware. Often, societies say that dogs may bite, so we shouldn't have them. I try to make them aware on how not to get bitten," says Aras.



CANINE CARE Sunil Kuttam with stray dogs

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

IN DEVELOPED COUNTRIES, STREET DOG POPULATIONS ARE CONTROLLED NOT JUST THROUGH STERILISATION PROGRAMMES BUT ALSO BY PROVIDING HOMELESS ANIMALS SHELTERS AND PARKS

In developed countries, street dog populations are controlled not just through sterilisation programmes but also by providing homeless animals shelters and parks. The Noida Authority is taking some lessons from the US and is planning to build 18 shelter homes for dogs in the city with the help of RWAs. Run by the RWAs, they will provide a place for homeless dogs to stay and be treated for illness. There is also a dog park being built in Sector 135.

It is important that we find a balance between dog lovers and those who are yet to be comfortable with them. Those with dog phobias say their fears should also be respected. "I went through a horrible situation with a gang of dogs as a child. I cannot be near dogs without feeling very sick. I am not saying kill street dogs but at least leave areas where a person can be without having to face them," says 19-year-old Mumbai-based student Akshay Narain. Dog experts say that this can be done if feeding is done in only one part of the society so that the dogs' area is confined to that space. Multiple feeders in the same society with multiple locations trains dogs to roam the entire society instead of a part of it.

Street dogs are valuable to many, even as they are frightening to others. Sensitisation on the value of dogs and how to behave around them, sterilisation to control numbers and pack aggressiveness and feeding homeless dogs in planned public spaces can serve as the foundation of such a balance. ■

with Rahul Naronha, Rohit Parihar and Manish Dixit